YOUR MAGAZINE FROM GALLIONS

thamesview

NEWS • EVENTS • COMPETITIONS

OCTOBER 2011
www.gallionsha.co.uk



NEWS, VIEWS & EVENTS FOR YOU TO ENJOY

TIPS FOR LOOKING AFTER YOUR HOME THIS WINTER

IMPROVEMENTS IN YOUR NEIGHBOURHOOD

Gallions Housing Association

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HELLO

Welcome to this edition of Thamesview. It seems that Autumn is now upon us and so to help you plan for Winter we have included information about how to best prepare your home for the colder months as well as tell you about exciting plans for some neighbourhoods.

With the magazine this month you will find our Annual Report 2010/11. It looks back over the last year and tells you how Gallions has performed and how we compare against other landlords.

The report was written by a team of residents and staff and we hope you find it interesting and informative.

If you would like to be involved in the team that write Thamesview, the annual report or other information leaflets then please get in touch.

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thamesview@gallionsha.co.uk

FSC www.fsc.org MIX Paper from responsible sources FSC® C009381

Gallions Residents Group Thamesmead

Gallions Housing Association

MY HOME ONLINE

This summer we launched My Home Online - a great free service that gives you secure access to your account information 24 hours a day!

All you need to do is visit www.gallionsha.co.uk/myhomeonline and you will be guided through the registration process. Online you will be able to look at your rent statements, home and communal repairs history and transfer applications. It's so easy and simple!

To help you get started come along to our free drop-in training sessions at our office at Titmuss Avenue on:

TUESDAY 1 NOVEMBER
Anytime between 10am and 12pm

THURSDAY 10 NOVEMBER
Anytime between 1pm and 3pm

The system is really easy to use and individual training sessions will take around 15 minutes. If you can't make the drop in sessions then please give Anita Glover a call on 0300 123 1237 as we will be running more sessions soon.



RECYCLING GETS REWARDS FOR THAMESMEAD RESIDENTS



The first phase of an exciting new reward scheme has been rolled out to 2,000 homes in East Thamesmead.

London Green Points rewards people for recycling, reusing and reducing their waste. Participants have access to a range of discounts and offers from local retailers as well as points for days out.
The scheme is being supported by Gallions and the London Borough of Bexley. For those of you who can take part information packs have been delivered to your home and Stephen Bates from London Green Points is urging residents to activate their accounts; "The sooner you activate, the sooner you can start earning rewards".

You can get in touch with them on 020 7326 5082 if you need more information.



DIY TRAINING

The DIY training for residents was a roaring success. 11 residents attended trying their hand at basic plumbing, carpentry and painting & decorating. Everyone was able to get some practical advice and 'have a go'!

Comments from residents included –
'Excellent' 'Very informative' 'Lots of fun' 'Gallions have got it right'
'Would be good to have more sessions covering different skills'

We will be putting on more of these events over the summer next year with promotion starting in early Spring.





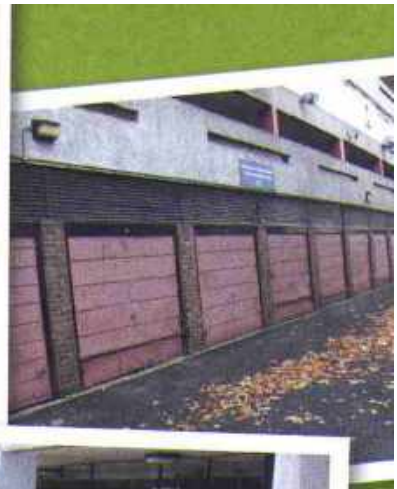
OPERATION CUBITT

In July Gallions worked closely with the London Borough of Greenwich, the Police and the DVLA to identify and remove cars that were abandoned and untaxed from around certain neighbourhoods.
The exercise resulted in:

- 5 cars taken away for scrap
- 9 cars taken into storage (if the owners want to reclaim they have to pay £200 plus storage)
- 3 cars had 15 day warning notices placed on them

The operation will be carried out again later this year.







IMPROVED REPAIRS SERVICE

To improve our repairs service we now offer two repair categories:- choice which is completed within 15 days and emergency which is done within 4 hours.

As part of the improvements you can also now receive a text message to confirm your appointment time. We also have a wide choice of dates and times that you can choose to make getting repairs done that bit easier.

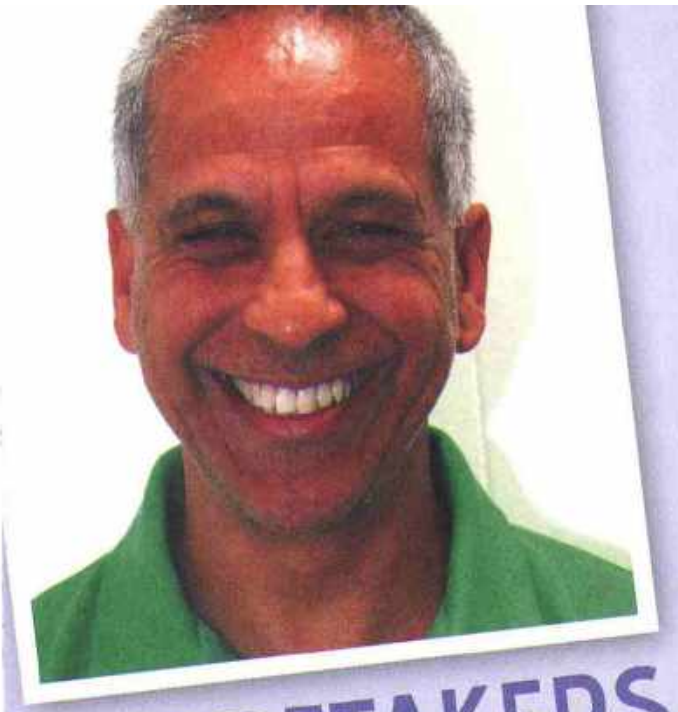
NEIGHBOURHOOD IMPROVEMENTS

Over the last few months we have been continuing to make environmental improvements around the Maran Way and Byron Close areas.

Improvements made so far include:

- Refurbishment and Upgrading of External Lighting
- New Visual door Entry systems
- Re-decoration of communal areas
- Introduction of Decorative Mesh and Panels to Stairways
- New Front Entrance Doors
- New Flooring in some areas
- Securing of Garage areas

In the coming weeks we will be looking at ways to improve our waste recycling facilities around this area. All of these improvements are in addition to our routine planned programmes of works that we publicise and carry out each year.



CARETAKERS SERVICE

During the summer we introduced a new caretaker service in all our blocks in Thamesmead. Each of our blocks now has a named caretaker who is responsible for cleaning and minor repairs in communal areas. Our caretakers are easy to spot as they all wear green t-shirts! Here we meet Roy Hill one of our caretakers to see what he does.

What sort of things do you do during a working day? Each day is varied, but I always clean the lifts, balconies, stair wells and walls in the blocks.

Has working in certain blocks helped you get to know more residents? Yes it has - I really enjoy talking to the residents. When I first started I said 'Good Morning' to residents and some were shocked, but now they take time to stop and talk to me!

What made you want to become a caretaker? The job was local and it involved doing active work which I enjoy. I also like being able to talk to residents and see how the work I do makes a difference to them.

What did you do before you joined Gallions? I worked in a warehouse.

If you had one wish for helping blocks stay tidy what would it be? No more leaves! My blocks are surrounded by trees so leaves blow in all day.

Check your block noticeboard to find out who your caretaker is and their contact details.

Interviewed by Emma O'Connor.

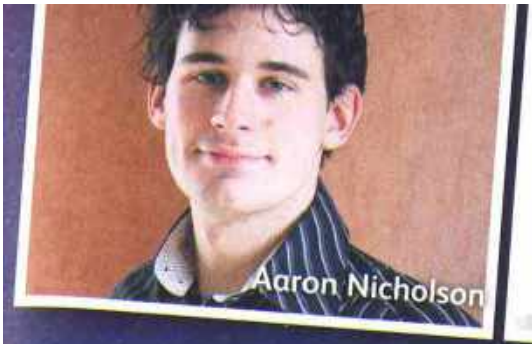
WHO'S AT YOUR DOOR?

Gallions has contractors who may visit your home to carry out repairs. The contractors may be driving a vehicle or wearing a uniform with the company name on it, or they may even be someone who you know or have seen before, but you should always still ask them to show their ID and to explain the reason for their visit.

Our quality standards require that all contractors do this so please ask for ID before allowing them into your home. For your own safety we want to ensure that only legitimate contractors are allowed in your home and not criminals who may be posing as contractors.

If our contractors do not have ID, or their ID does not look genuine, do not let them into your home and ask them to wait whilst you contact Gallions to check who they are. If they are genuine they will be happy to wait while you do this.

Stay safe so if in doubt – don't let them in.







WHO'S MY TENANCY OFFICER?

STARTER TENANCIES

Gallions gives all new tenants renting with us a 12-month Starter Tenancy when they first move in.

The Starter Tenancies allows us to tackle anti-social behaviour more effectively by giving us the ability to:

- Carry out monitoring visits to tenants during that first 12 months to check they are keeping to the terms of the tenancy. The tenancy is then converted to an Assured Tenancy if everything is ok.

- If the conditions of the tenancy are broken we can end a Starter Tenancy by obtaining a court order for eviction.

  The most common reasons for this include causing a nuisance to neighbours, using the property for things that are against the law, living in another property and/or subletting the property and not paying the rent.

Our Tenancy Officers can help you with lots of different issues connected to your tenancy. This includes viewings and sign ups, transfers, mutual exchanges, changes of name, changes in the household, starter tenancy visits at 6 weeks and 8 weeks, extra visits to vulnerable tenants, abandonments and tenancy inspections prior to mutual exchanges or transfers.

We have three Tenancy Officers who work in the following areas:

- Jackie Van Wyk - Broadwaters, Crossways, Greenmead, some of Lesnes, Manor Way, some of Parkview, some of Southmere, some of Waterfield

- Irene Taylor - Abbey Wood, Belvedere, Erith, some of Lesnes, Moorings, some of Parkview, some of Southmere, some of Waterfield

- Aaron Nicholson - Tower Hamlets, Newham, Lakeview Court, Heron Court

If you have any questions about your tenancy contact us on 0300 123 1237.

"Your Tenancy Officer can help with transfers, and tenancy changes"



Do you need mediation?

Mediation gives residents a chance to sort out disagreements with the help of an independent mediator, who will not take sides. The service is free to our tenants and is entirely confidential.

The types of disagreements may be over noise, children, pets, shared areas, different lifestyles, parking or other nuisances. Normally both parties will be invited to meet, along with the mediators, to discuss and resolve the problem in a calm and controlled way.

Meetings will usually take place in a neutral location and usually last around 2 hours when hopefully an agreement can be reached. If a meeting is not possible, the mediator may still act as a go-between.

If you have a problem that you think can be helped with mediation then let us know and we will make a referral on your behalf. Please call the enforcement team on 0300 123 1237.

ALWAYS REPORT IT

If you are affected by the anti-social behaviour of your neighbours or suspect one of our properties is being used for things that are against the law or is being sub-let, then let us know.

Since January 2011 residents have made 631 reports of anti-social behaviour to our Enforcement Team which help us to stamp out this behaviour and evict those responsible.

We are currently assisting police with the identification of those involved in crime and anti social behaviour within some of our neighbourhoods, so if you have any information please report it confidentially to Crimestoppers 0800 555 111 or our Customer Contact Team on 0300 123 1237.

LOOKING AT GALLIONS SERVICES

Gallions works with residents to monitor the different services that we provide. We are keen to hear your views on Gallions' performance so please contact Jane Lester on 020 8308 4089 or email jlester@gallionsha.co.uk if you have time to answer these questions and can give us your feedback. The results will be published in Thamesview next year.

CAN YOU HELP US ANSWER THE FOLLOWING QUESTIONS:

Do Gallions keep the neighbourhood and communal areas clean and safe? Do they work in partnership with their tenants in order to accomplish this?

Does Gallions act to help local communities thrive? This can be through jobs and training help, keeping the streets clean and safe; offering good housing and helping residents to get to know each other?

Does Gallions work in partnership with other public agencies to help reduce anti-social behaviour?

DOES GALLIONS:

- Tell residents what service to expect from Gallions?
- Look out for possible trouble spots and take steps to stop them turning into real problems?
- Stop problems quickly before they get serious, using all means available, from mediation to legal action?
- Make it easy for tenants and other residents to report anti-social behaviour?
- Keep victims and witnesses well informed about their case and give them support while it's being sorted out?

COMING TO →→→ THAMESMEAD

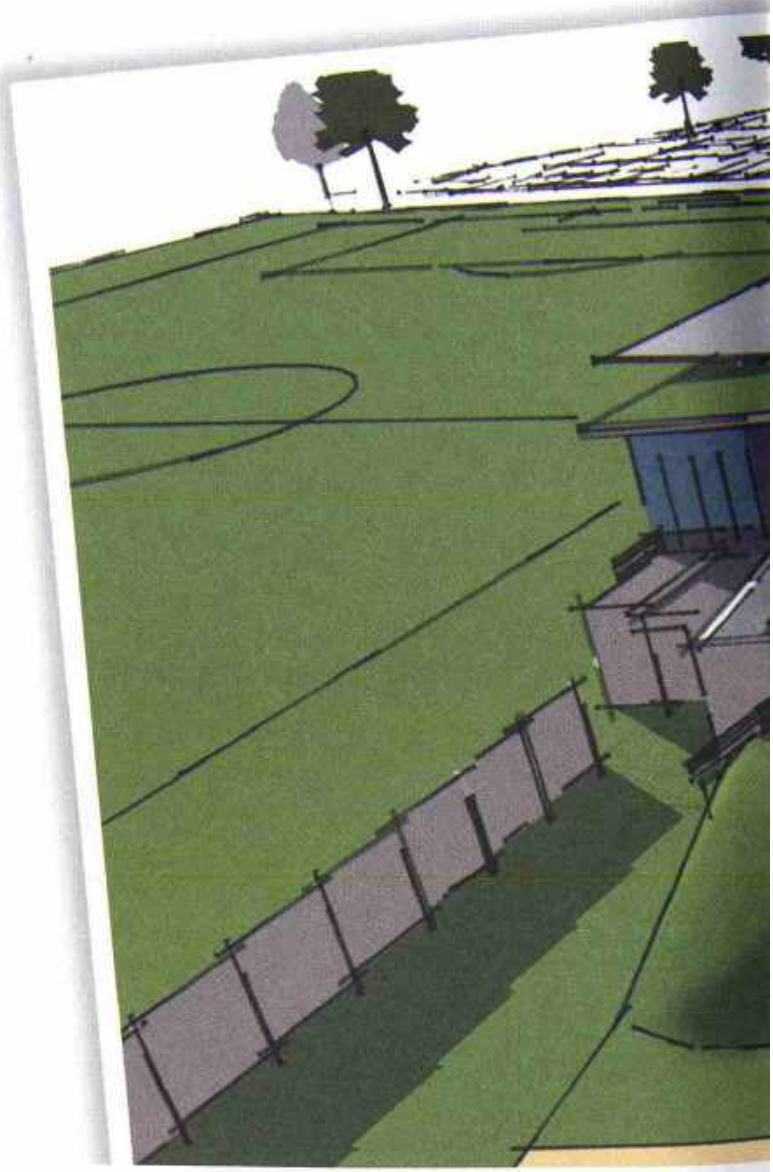
The Link Thamesmead is a stunning, world-class, state-of-the-art community hub based in the arches under the Harrow Manor Way flyover, which is being built with a £5million grant Trust Thamesmead secured from the Department of Education's myplace programme. Aimed at young people but available for use by the whole community, The Link Thamesmead will offer a range of activities and facilities in an exciting, safe and welcoming place.

OUR NINE STRIKING ARCHES WILL OFFER:

- Activities – singing, drama, acting, fitness gym, motorcycle workshops, a music studio, climbing wall and ropes course, water sports and more!
- Opportunities – training, volunteering, work experience, advice and guidance
- Venues for hire – classrooms, offices, meeting rooms, rehearsal spaces and a 160 seat performance studio.

Thamesmead Gym and the Archway Project are open every day, even whilst the build is taking place and we are on course to open fully in the first half of 2012.

Keep up to date with the latest news and make a connection: thelinkthamesmead.co.uk or contact The Link's Centre Manager, Mark Blundell, T: 020 8320 4470 or E: mblundell@thelinkthamesmead.co.uk.

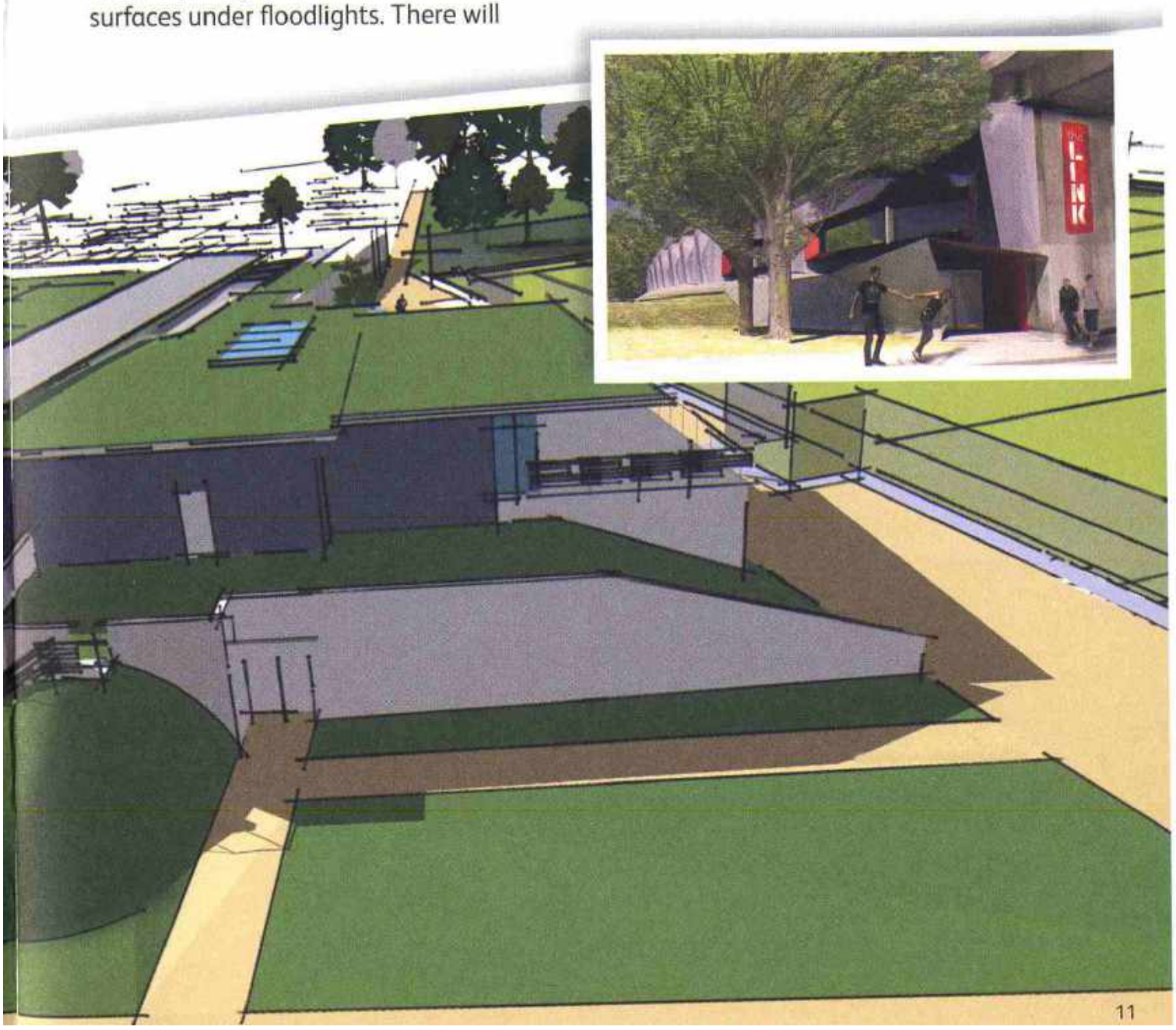


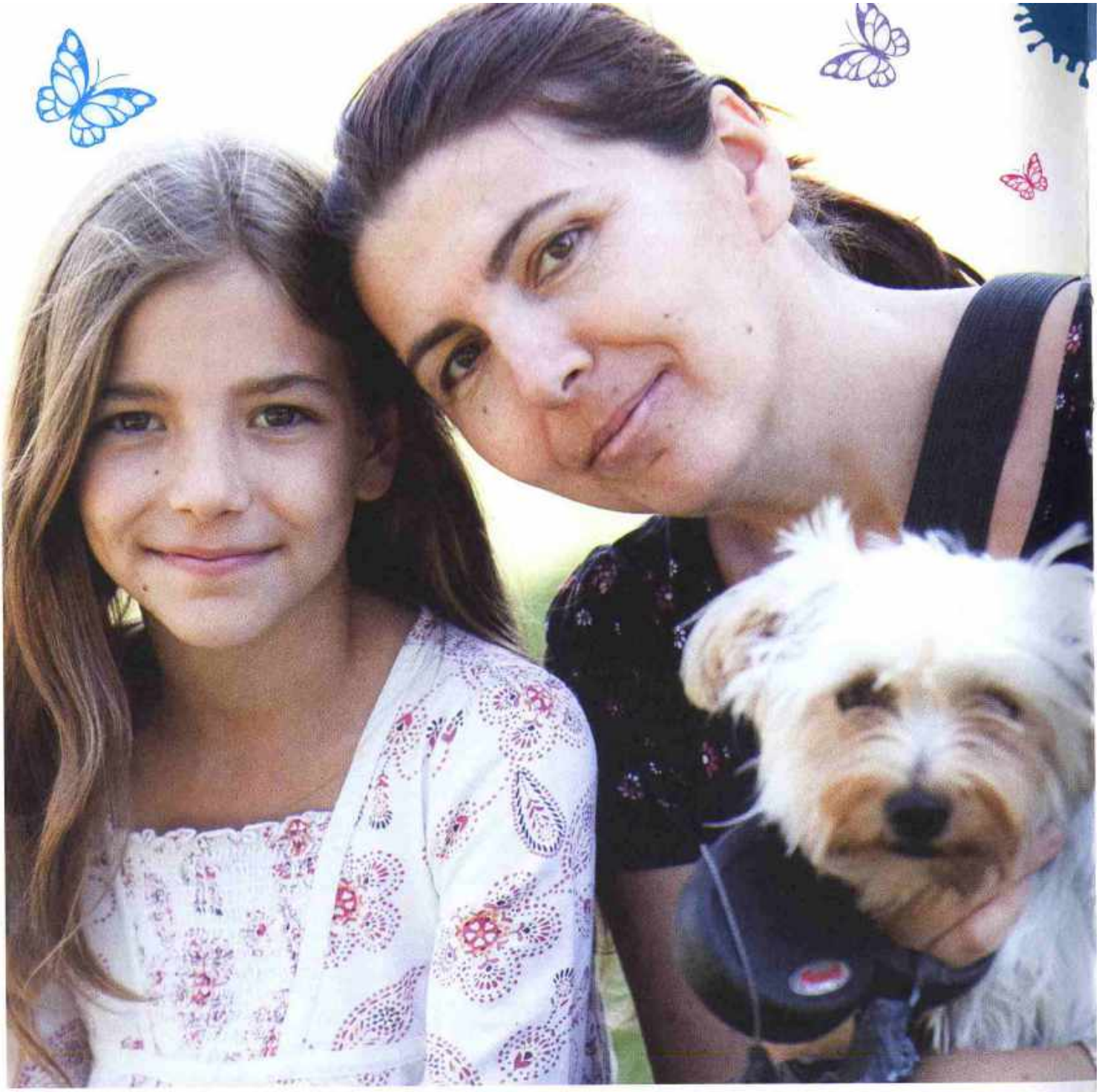
Sporting Club Thamesmead is Trust Thamesmead's new, multi-million pound modern and welcoming community facility which is being built in Bayliss Avenue, North Thamesmead. It is on track to open early next year (2012) and will offer a full size synthetic turf pitch, grass football pitches, a multi-use games area, indoor multi-activity space, changing rooms, a café/bar with Sky Sports and some great function rooms.

Activities will include seven-a-side football leagues, sports schools for many activities including netball, basketball, hockey and football, many of them on all-weather surfaces under floodlights. There will also be fitness and activity programmes, children's birthday parties and a range of programmes and activities for residents of Thamesmead that will offer new opportunities around skills, training and work opportunities. It's also a great venue for receptions, parties and corporate events.

To pre-register for FREE membership visit www.sportingclubthamesmead.co.uk. Want to know more?

Email: questions@sportingclubthamesmead.co.uk Follow us on Twitter @ScTfootball











"free advice from our Welfare Benefits Team and other local agencies about benefits, tax credits and budgeting."

FAMILY FUN AND BENEFITS DAY

Don't miss our next family fun and benefits day on Thursday 27 October. At this event you will be able to get free advice from our Welfare Benefits Team and other local agencies about benefits, tax credits and budgeting. Plus, there will be free refreshments, face painting, balloon modelling, arts and crafts and the chance to win £30 in shopping vouchers just for attending!

June Fraser a resident at Timothy House urges all residents to attend the day. She said "I contacted the welfare benefits team at Gallions when DWP was clawing back money from my benefits and I was struggling with my finances. The team helped me to reduce the claw back to an amount I could easily afford and they also helped with other debts I had with Thames Water and EDF.

They helped me to submit applications and were able to get them to clear my Thames Water arrears of £2267.32 and EDF debt of £675.46. I would like to say a big thank you to the Welfare Benefits team and would recommend this service to all other residents."

So come along on the day and see how we can help you!

Thursday 27th October 2011
11am until 6pm (pop in at any time!)
The Business Academy Bexley
Yarnton Way, Erith, DA18 4DW

Buses 180, 401, 601, B11 all stop on Yarnton Way, right outside the school.

Contact the Communications Team on 0300 123 1237 to find out more or to confirm your place. See you there!

SOUTHMERE VILLAGE REGENERATION UPDATE

Gallions now has a funding agreement in place to go ahead with Phase 3 of the Southmere Village Regeneration (subject to planning permission). This phase will see around 290 homes, new shops and a library being built over 3 years starting on site in 2012.

We will write to everyone directly affected by the scheme with information about how and when they will be involved and what to expect from the regeneration.

We will also be running consultation and information sessions in the One Stop Shop at Tavy Bridge, so please look out for more information in the next couple of months.



DATES FOR YOUR DIARY

FUNDRAISING QUIZ NIGHT CHALLENGE

ST JOHNS BAPTIST CHURCH - ERITH

29th October >> 7pm - 11pm >> www.stjohnserith.org

DANSON PARK FIREWORKS

DANSON PARK - WELLING

5th November >> 6pm – 8pm >> www.dansonparkfireworks.co.uk

FESTIVE GROTTO AND SEASONAL GIFTS

BROADWAY SHOPPING CENTRE - BEXLEYHEATH

12 November - 24 December >> www.communityhospice.org.uk

ERITH CHRISTMAS TREE FESTIVAL

CHRIST CHURCH - ERITH

10th – 12th December >> Various times >> www.erithctf.co.uk.

Q	N	W	R	E	T	R	R	T	H	Y	U	U
H	J	K	K	L	G	S	P	M	O	J	I	S
G	C	F	X	D	G	S	A	A	I	Z	S	X
L	T	B	K	Y	U	E	N	R	B	E	V	C
U	N	I	S	D	N	P	F	L	G	R	H	E
Z	E	R	W	E	P	E	I	R	H	I	C	N
B	M	S	K	R	O	W	E	R	I	F	Y	O
B	A	N	Y	M	W	P	E	O	G	N	P	S
A	I	M	C	D	D	Y	Z	C	A	O	Q	A
U	L	E	E	T	E	N	T	S	Y	B	U	E
O	R	P	G	L	R	K	L	J	T	H	J	R
V	A	L	O	N	D	O	N	S	S	D	A	T
R	P	T	N	Y	M	U	Q	I	E	O	F	P

WIN WITH OUR WORDSEARCH

In this wordsearch we have hidden six words which relate to Guy Fawkes. Find them all and you could win a £30 shopping voucher.

BONFIRE
FIREWORKS
GUNPOWDER
LONDON
PARLIAMENT
TREASON

DID YOU KNOW...

During Guy Fawkes involvement with the Gunpowder Plot, Fawkes called himself John Johnson when he was arrested and asked to give his name.

It took up to four days of torture for Guy Fawkes to admit to his part in the Gunpowder Plot. Fawkes and other people involved in the Gunpowder Plot were tried on January 31st 1606 and then hung, drawn and quartered in the Old Palace Yard in Westminster.

Many people believe Fawkes was thrown onto a bonfire, however that did not happen and only happens now to straw dummies of him.

Please return your completed wordsearch and details to: Anita Glover, Gallions Housing Association, Freepost RSLT-LYEG-HZAL, PO BOX 268, Sidcup, DA15 0FB or drop it into our reception by 18th November 2011. The winner will be selected at random.

Name: .....

Address: .....

.....

.....

Telephone: .....

Email: .....

Congratulations to Benedicita Olcojie of Teeswater Court who was the winner of our last wordsearch competition.

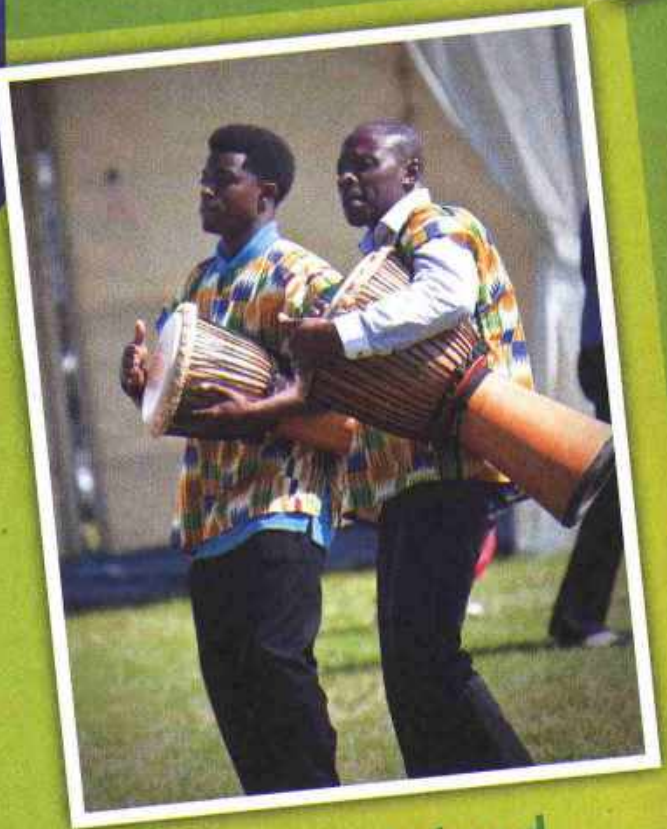
Tenants view...

Autumn's here and what a productive year it has been for the Gallions Residents Group! We have worked closely with Gallions to monitor and improve services, welcomed new members to the group and got together with Trust Thamesmead to organise some great community events. We have lots to look forward to in the coming months and in 2012 as well!

Picnic in the Park Success

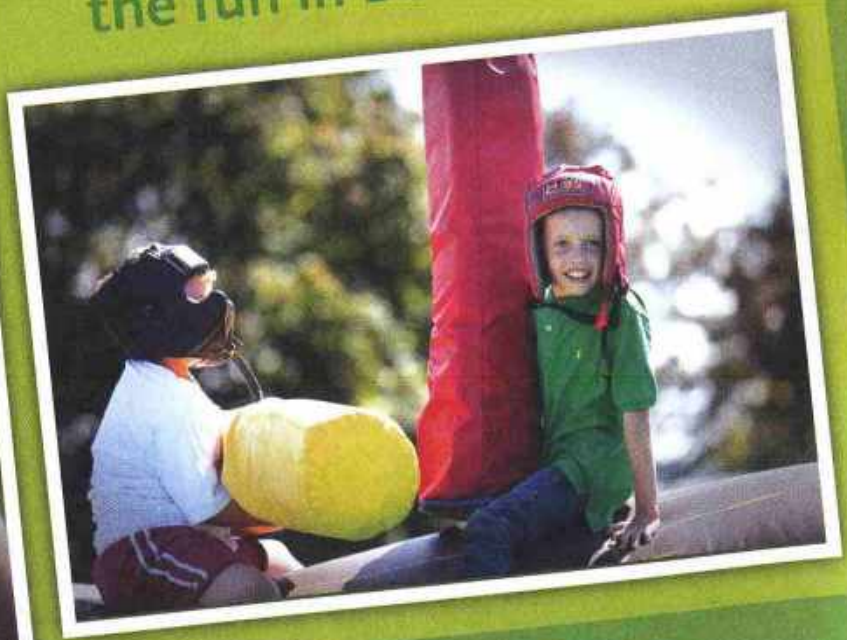
The Gallions Residents Group joined forces with Trust Thamesmead to run two fun family events this summer. During the days in August residents enjoyed free ice cream, bouncy castles, face painting, arts and crafts, music and much more.

It was great to chat to so many other local people too and find out what they think about where they live. We hope to help run similar events again in 2012!



"900 residents joined the fun in Birchmere Park"





New members needed for Tavy Bridge group

"Get involved with the regeneration project"

Tavy Bridge Regeneration Resident's Action Group (TBRRAG) has been active since 2004, organising events like the Big Lunch and influencing the progress of phases one and two of the regeneration project. With phase three starting soon they would like more residents from the Southmere area of Thamesmead to join the group. If you would like to get involved pop along to their next meeting at 7pm on Monday 31st October at the One Stop Shop on Tavy Bridge. For more information please call 0300 123 1237 and ask to speak to Helen Chambers.





Thamesmead Furniture Recycle

"New opening hours for recycling project"

Thamesmead Furniture Recycle based at Tavy Bridge is now open every Tuesday at 10am-2pm, Thursday 12pm-2pm and Saturday for collection and delivery only. The scheme helps residents recycle their good quality used furniture within the community; so for a small fee you can give your home a makeover!

The team can now collect your donations and offer delivery for a small charge. If you would like to volunteer to help run the shop or want to donate a piece of good quality, unwanted furniture call 07925 019 386 or 07925 019 390.

Who to call?

"Gallions has two dedicated phone lines for residents to call."

In April, Gallions changed its telephone service so that there are two teams to deal with calls from residents:

0300 123 1237 for general enquiries such as:

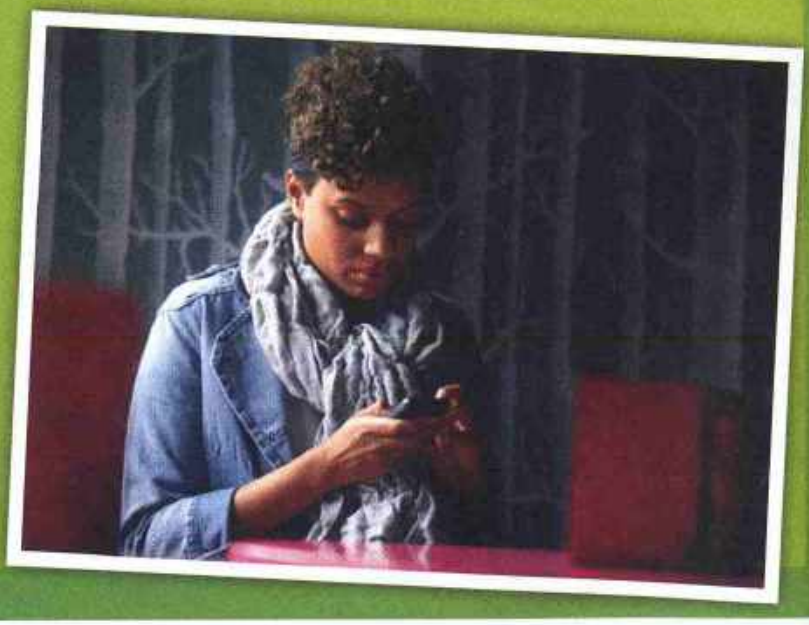
- Applying for housing or a transfer
- Paying your rent
- Benefits advice
- Getting involved with Gallions
- Complaints, comments or compliments
- Planned home improvements
- Disability aids and adaptations
- Making your own home improvements
- Reporting anti-social behaviour
- Changing or ending your tenancy
- Contents insurance
- Renting a garage
- Rubbish dumping (from 1st November 2011)
- Cleaning (from 1st November 2011)
- Abandoned vehicles (from 1st November 2011)
- Parks and green spaces (from 1st November 2011)
- Anything else!

Tenants view...

0300 123 1238 for:

- Reporting a repair that is inside your home
- Reporting communal repairs, for example problems with lifts, door entry systems, lighting and glazing
- Getting an update about any type of repair
- Gas safety inspections
- Advice about condensation or damp

Since April there have been more than 15,000 calls made to the new repairs phone line. At first there were some delays in the time it took for a call to be answered. This was because the staffing requirement had been underestimated but this has now been resolved and in August calls were answered in 18 seconds on average.



Metal and cable theft update

"Report metal theft to the police or crimestoppers"



There have been some recent incidents of metal and cable theft in the Moorings area of Thamesmead. The types of items stolen were:

- Children's Play Equipment
- Lift Equipment
- Lightning Protection to Buildings
- Door Entry and CCTV cabling
- Door Entry Panels and Posts
- Signs
- Copper pipes and cylinders
- Central Heating Boilers
- Fire Safety Equipment
- Metal Bins
- Drain Covers
- Lead Flashings for roofs

When these items are stolen it puts residents and members of the public at risk from injury and fire and also disrupts daily life for residents.

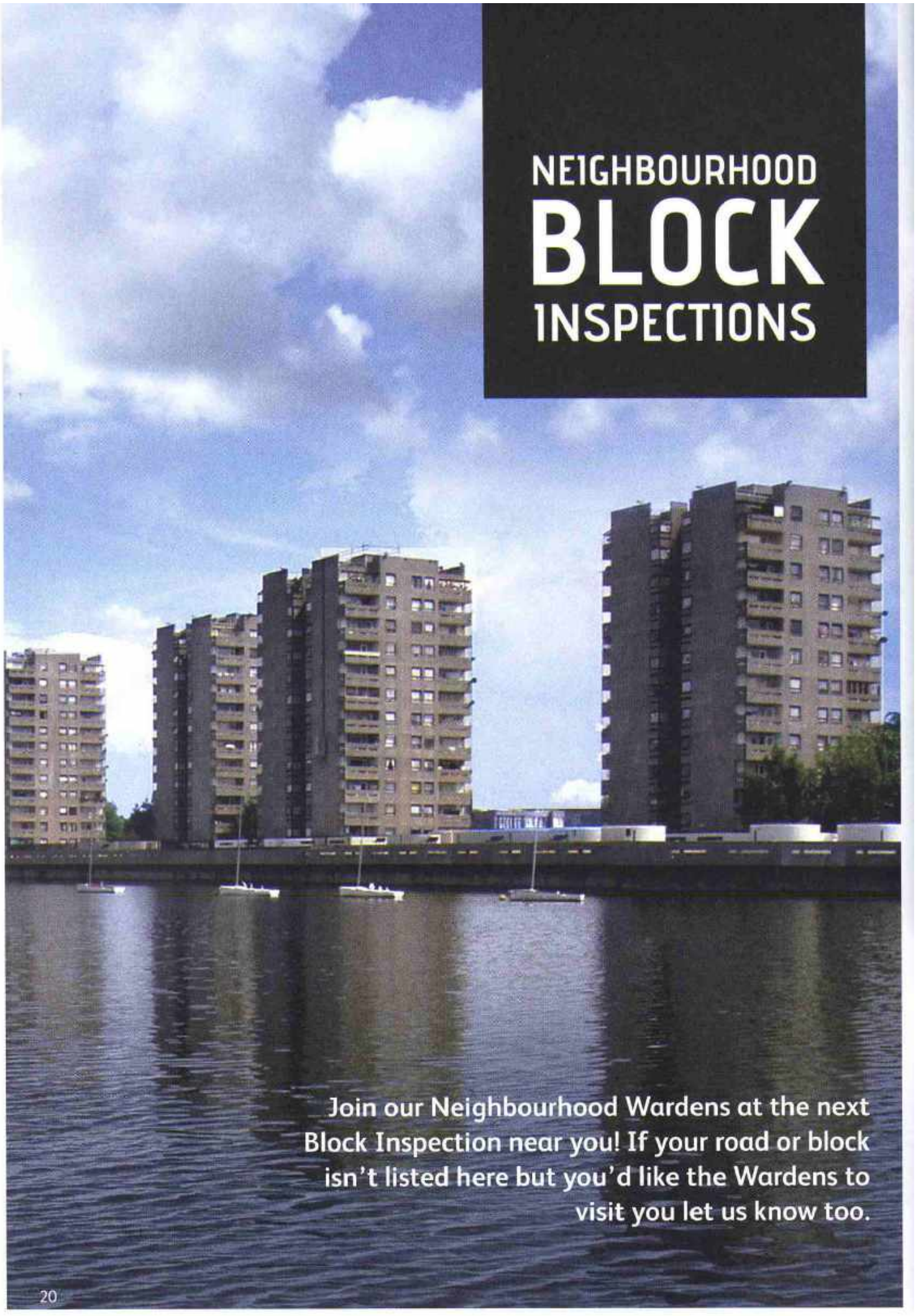
Gallions also has to pay for the replacement of these items which sometimes means planned maintenance work (like new kitchens and bathrooms) has to be delayed or cancelled. If you notice anything suspicious happening where you live please report it to the police or crimestoppers on 0800 555 111.

Tackling anti-social behaviour in the community

"Report any issues confidentially"

The riots in London this summer were an extreme example of anti-social behaviour. Luckily, in Thamesmead the damage was not extensive and no-one was hurt.

If you experience anti-social behaviour make sure you report it to Gallions in confidence by calling 0300 123 1237. They will investigate your report and let you know the outcome if you leave your contact details.



NEIGHBOURHOOD BLOCK INSPECTIONS

Join our Neighbourhood Wardens at the next Block Inspection near you! If your road or block isn't listed here but you'd like the Wardens to visit you let us know too.

ABBEY WOOD

3 November
St Josephs Court
Felixstowe Road

BROADWATERS

4 November
Whinchat Road
Wren Path

7 November
Wigeon Path
Redwing Path

CROSSWAY

11 November
Phoenix Point
Ringside Court

LESNES

9 November
Coralline Walk
Evenlode House

10 November
Clewer House
Maplin House
Wyfold House

17 November
Hibernia House
Radley House
Duxford House

MOORINGS

22 November
Harold Wilson House

28 November
Simon Court
Chadwick Court
Manning Court

29 November
Besant Court
Mill Court
Cross Court

PARKVIEW

8 November
Shire Court
Teeswater Court
Buckwheat Court

16 November
Maran Way
Argali House
Dexter House
Harlequin House

23 November
Masham House
Jacob House
Clydesdale House

24 November
Trefoil House
Timothy House
Muscovy House

SLADE GREEN

3 November
Old Church Court

SOUTHMERE

30 November
Tilehurst Point
Blewbury House

WATERFIELD

15 November
Cobden Court
Bright Court
Hazlitt Court

18 November
Shaftesbury Court
Wilberforce Court
Kingsley Court

21 November
Disraeli Close

"Call us on 0300 123 1237 and we'll let you know what time to meet."

HOW WELL ARE WE DOING?

This performance chart shows our performance as a landlord so far during the 2011 financial year compared to 2010. If you would like to join our residents group and help us monitor and improve what we do please contact Helen Chambers on 0300 123 1237.

Description	2010/11	2011/12	Target	Performance Trend	Current Status
Overall satisfaction with service	82%	82%	75%	↔	☺
Empty homes re-let period (a lower figure is better)	30 days	31 days	26 days	↓	☹
Emergency repairs completed within timescale	99%	99%	98%	↔	☺
Calls answered within 20 seconds (Customer Contact Team)	83%	89%	80%	↑	☺
Complaints answered within timescale	90%	97%	90%	↑	☺
Satisfaction with anti-social behaviour process	91%	95%	84%	↑	☺
Rent collected	99%	96%	100%	↓	☹

Performance Status		Overall Performance Trend	
☹	Performance is below target	↑	Performance is better than last year
☺	Performance is above target	↓	Performance is worse than last year
		↔	Performance is the same as last year

HOMEOWNER NEWS

PAYING FOR MAJOR WORKS

Residents living in The Moorings will have received a letter outlining planned maintenance works in the pipeline for their area.

It is a condition of the lease that leaseholders contribute towards Major Works when they are carried out to their block or estate. If you find you cannot pay your service charge bill straight away don't ignore it! It will not go away and you could end up losing your home if you don't try to pay it.

First of all you should see if you are entitled to any benefits. Leaseholders cannot get Housing Benefit but you may be entitled to Council Tax Benefit and perhaps Income Support. If you are in receipt of certain payments from the Department for Work and Pensions, as a leaseholder you may qualify for assistance with some housing costs.

There are also ways we can help you spread the cost of a large bill:

- Firstly, you can ask to pay by monthly installments. This will allow you to spread the cost over 6 monthly payments. If the repayments are still too high you can apply to spread the debt over a longer period, subject to your income and expenditure. We also reserve the right to charge interest on your debt.
- If you cannot afford to spread the cost over six months, you may wish to consider obtaining a loan, which may spread the cost over several years.

There are three main ways you can get a loan to cover all or part of your charges:

- an ordinary bank loan (ask your bank for details)
- a secured loan
- an equity loan

A secured loan is one that is 'secured' against your property, like a mortgage. It means that the lender has a right to recover the loan from the value of your property (by selling it if necessary) if you do not make the proper repayments. You could lose your home if you do not keep up the payments on a secured loan. You should always obtain independent financial and legal advice before proceeding.

There are a number of different schemes designed to assist older homeowners to release the equity value in their home. It is particularly important that you receive legal and financial advice before entering into one of the schemes. You may wish to consider using the service provided by the Home Improvement Trust, which is a not-for-profit organisation aimed at helping homeowners aged 60 or above, disabled homeowners or homeowners living with disabled person/s. Call them on 0800 783 7569 or you can email them at info@houseproud.org.uk

Gallions Housing Association

Increasing numbers of people in London who thought they would never be able to own their own homes are now achieving this ambition through shared ownership. With FIRST STEPS Shared Ownership (formerly known as New Build HomeBuy) you can buy a share of a housing association property and pay rent on the part of the home that is owned by the association. Over time you can buy extra shares until you own the property outright.

L&Q is the FIRST STEPS Agent for South London. As well as providing the facility to apply on line, the FIRST STEPS website, www.firststepslondon.org also advertises the properties that are being marketed for home ownership and for intermediate rent in Bexley and the other parts of SE London.

The FIRST STEPS Agent Team works closely with Bexley Council and Gallions Housing Association to give first time buyers that live in Bexley the opportunity to access good quality affordable housing. Gallions and other housing associations are currently developing a number of one, two and three bedroom FIRST STEPS shared ownership properties in Crayford; Welling; Bexley; Sidcup; and Belvedere. There are also over hundreds of homes available in the South East London Boroughs of Bromley, Greenwich, Lewisham, and Southwark that may meet your needs.

If you would like to know more why not visit www.firststepslondon.org or call 0844 406 9997 to speak to an advisor to see whether you too can realise your ambition to own your own home. The line is open from 8.30am to 5.00pm on Mondays to Fridays.

BECOMING A HOME OWNER MAY BE MORE AFFORDABLE THAN YOU THINK...







RECTORY LANE SCHEME - SIDCUP

SCHEME INFORMATION

- 16 homes for shared ownership
- 11 homes for private sale
- 10 homes for general needs rent

LOCATION, LOCATION, LOCATION

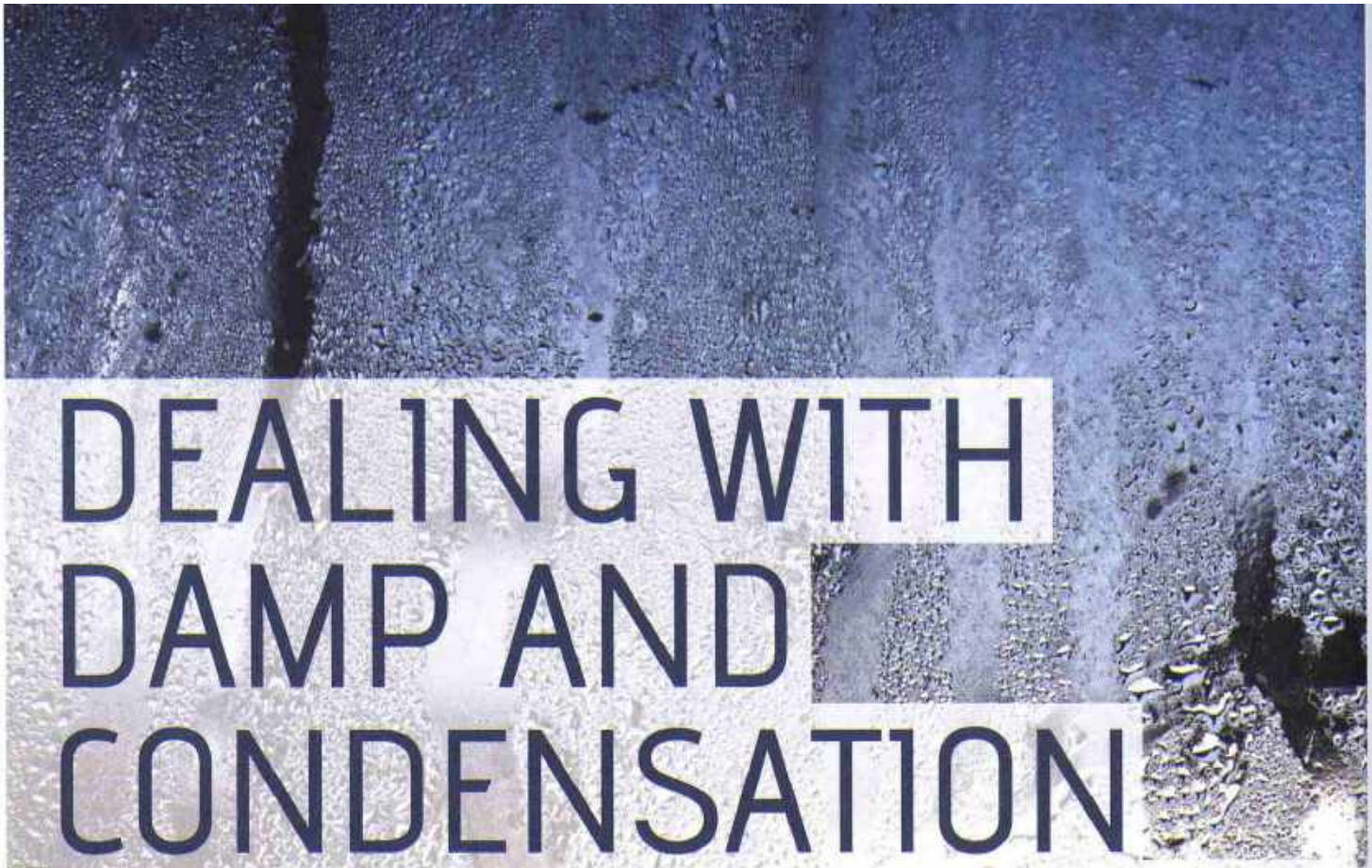
The new scheme is on Rectory Lane, Sidcup which is just off Sidcup Hill.
The homes are within a 20 minute walk of Sidcup station, which connects to London Mainline stations. There are good bus links to New Eltham, Sidcup and Foots Cray stations and excellent road links to A2, M25 and A20/M20.

LOCAL AMENITIES

The homes are at the end of the main high street in Sidcup which offers a variety of shops and restaurants and a local Morrisons supermarket a short walk away. A larger Tesco store is less than two miles away at Foots Cray.

The scheme is due to complete around March 2012.





DEALING WITH DAMP AND CONDENSATION

As we approach the winter months the weather gets colder and wetter and you will use your central heating a lot more. As a result the possibility of condensation and damp occurring in your home can increase. Here's some tips on how you can help to reduce this happening.

WHAT IS CONDENSATION?

Air contains moisture. Warm air acts like a sponge and soaks up moisture, but if air is cold, it can't hold all the moisture and it condenses as tiny drops of water. You will notice this most on windows on a cold morning. It can also be seen on mirrors after a bath or shower, and on cold surfaces such as tiles or cold walls. Condensation normally appears on or near windows, in corners, and in or behind wardrobes and cupboards.

From our experience many residents think they have roof or other leaks when signs of water appear but this is often not the case and it is condensation.

WHAT CAN I DO TO REDUCE CONDENSATION?

- Wipe down windows and sills every morning or when the water droplets appear
- Fit condensation channels and sponge strips to windows to collect the condensation
- Use anti-condensation paint with a mould inhibitor when decorating
- Leave a gap between furniture (such as a sofa or wardrobe) and walls, especially outside walls. It's always a good idea to position furniture against an internal wall

"Warm air acts like a sponge and soaks up moisture, but if air is cold, it can't hold all the moisture and it condenses as tiny drops of water"







- Drawn curtains or blinds make windows cooler (having double glazed windows with trickle vents can also help)

- Produce less moisture by:
  - Covering pans when cooking,
  - Not using paraffin or calor gas heaters
  - Not hanging up wet clothes indoors (dry them outside).
  - if you have to hang clothes indoors, try using the bathroom but keep the door closed and window open or fan on
  - always making sure tumble dryers vent to the outside (unless you have the self condensing type).

- Increase ventilation – this helps to remove moisture from the air:
  - keep windows slightly ajar or a trickle ventilator open
  - increased ventilation will mostly be needed when cooking, bathing, washing up and drying clothes
  - do not turn off extract fans in bathrooms and kitchens – they are there to circulate air to help reduce moisture

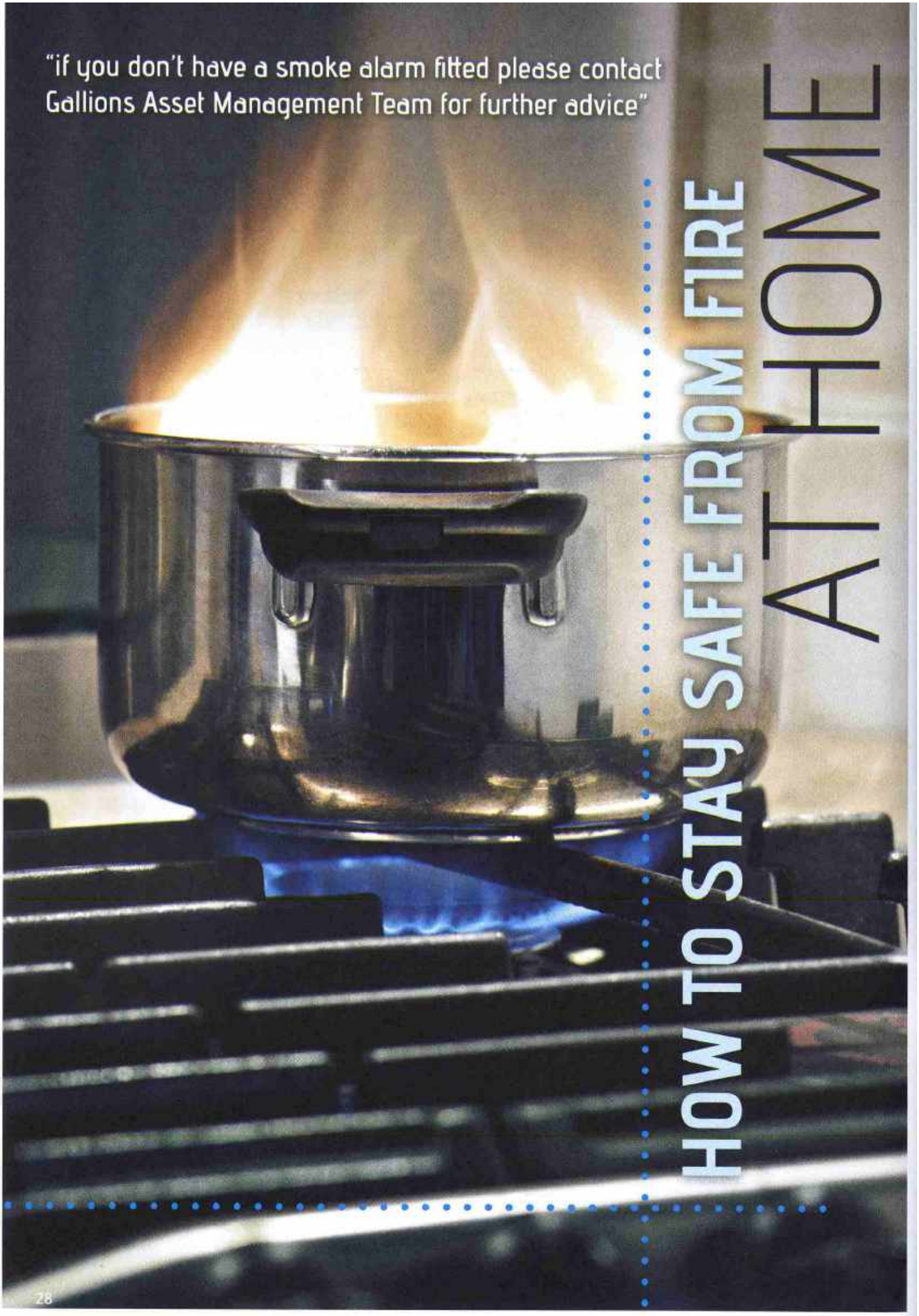
- Keep your home warm as condensation is less likely to occur:

  - insulate your loft and walls

  - draught-proof your windows and outside doors

  - do not block any permanent ventilators or draught-proof rooms where there is a fuel burning heater (e.g. gas fire) or cooker.

  - It's also a good idea to keep your heating on low all day even when there is no one at home. This is very important in flats and other homes where the bedrooms are not above a warm living room.



"if you don't have a smoke alarm fitted please contact Gallions Asset Management Team for further advice"

HOW TO STAY SAFE FROM FIRE AT HOME

We want you and your family to stay safe at all times so follow these fire safety guidelines.

To prevent fires in your home you should:

1. Have smoke alarms fitted in your home and make sure they are checked at least once a year – if you don't have a smoke alarm fitted please contact Gallions Asset Management Team for further advice

2. Take extra care in the kitchen and never leave the kitchen unattended when cooking

3. Don't overload plug sockets

4. Plan an escape route and keep exits clear so that your family can leave quickly if there is a fire

5. Make sure you do not block stairs and corridors of your building with rubbish and flammable material

6. Make sure you have adequate contents insurance to protect your belongings

What to do if a fire breaks out:

1. If the fire is in your home, close the door of the room where the fire is situated and leave your home immediately

2. Set off any fire alarms on your way out and do not use balconies unless they are part of a confirmed fire escape

3. When you leave the building do not use any lifts and call the fire brigade on 999 once you are safely outside

4. Tell the fire brigade the address of the fire and what floor the fire is on

5. Never re-enter the building.

   If a fire breaks out somewhere in your building and you are not affected by smoke and heat you will normally be safe to stay in your home. Move to a window so you can be seen and follow any instructions given to you by the fire brigade.

If your escape route is blocked by fire:

1. Alert everyone and then if possible gather them into one 'safe' room

2. Once inside this 'safe' room close the door and pack towels and pillows along the gaps

3. Don't open the door of a room if it feels warm when touched with the back of your hand

4. Go to the window and attract attention

5. If you are on the first floor and if it is safe to do so it may be possible to lower yourself to the ground using blankets or sheets. Don't try to jump and stay at the window if you are higher than the first floor

For more information about fire safety contact the London Fire Brigade on 0208 555 1200 or visit www.london-fire.gov.uk/SafetyAtHome. In an emergency always call 999.

See more about applying for contents insurance on page 30.

Kidsview WORDSEARCH

We have hidden six Halloween words in this wordsearch. Find them all and you could win a music fun pack!

M	R	N	R	B	V	C	L	O	A	K	I	Z
J	R	H	F	G	G	F	H	D	J	S	J	A
K	E	L	P	P	U	O	O	I	D	U	S	Y
X	D	Z	U	Q	S	W	T	E	E	R	K	T
H	T	J	M	V	T	B	R	N	V	M	A	L
A	A	D	P	F	Y	G	O	H	I	J	O	S
F	C	G	K	H	E	J	R	K	L	A	Y	P
J	K	K	I	L	A	P	B	O	X	I	C	I
F	C	G	N	E	E	W	O	L	L	A	H	D
I	A	U	M	Y	M	I	N	R	B	E	V	E
K	L	J	B	H	C	T	E	D	F	D	S	R
U	B	Y	C	T	L	C	A	E	D	W	U	S
I	T	O	I	P	N	H	L	N	M	B	L	V



HALLOWEEN
PUMPKIN
WITCH
DEVIL
CLOAK
BLACK CAT
SPIDERS

This competition is just for kids under 12. Please return your completed wordsearch and details to: Anita Glover, Gallions Housing Association, Freepost RSLT-LYEG-HZAL, PO Box 268, Sidcup, DA15 0FB or drop it into our reception by 18th November 2011. The winner will be selected at random.

Child's name:

Parent's name:

Address:

Telephone:

Well done to Billie Leman of Lipton Close who was the winner of our last competition.